

Final standings



1. Stellenbosch FC
2. Tottenham Hotspur
3. Punjab FC
4. Aston Villa
5. Everton
6. Muthoot FA
7. Crystal Palace
8. East Bengal



were huge confidence boosters for them, some players will have greater roles in the coming months.

Two of them, Kipgen and Pramveer, will join the National Camp for the U-20 SAFF Championships, while two more, Karish Soram and Thougamba Singh, will join the national camp for the U-17 edition of the tournament.

Kipgen, the star of India's victorious SAFF U-19 Championships last year, was Punjab's most reliable source of attack, scoring three goals and finishing the Next Gen Cup as India's highest goalscorer.

Usham, on the other hand, was omnipresent in the final third for his club during the tournament, netting the winner to complete the comeback against Everton.

As India enters the next edition of the U-17 and U-20 Championships as the defending champion, the international experience gained by these players could prove crucial for the national teams, both of which will play under new coaches — Ranjan Chaudhuri (U-20) and Ishfaq Ahmed (U-17).

Secondly, Punjab's success could

All smiles: Stellenbosch FC celebrates its title victory after staving off a strong challenge from Tottenham Hotspur and Punjab FC. PREMIER LEAGUE FOR INDIA

pave the way for a cultural shift in Indian football academies.

Under the guidance of its Director of Football, Nikolaos Topoliatis, Punjab has set up an academy in Mohali where players live, train, and play together, creating a camaraderie similar to that of Category 1 academies of Premier League sides like Aston Villa, Arsenal, and Crystal Palace.

Topoliatis, who was instrumental in building an astute youth infrastructure at Greek giant Olympiakos, has been with the Indian club since 2020 and has overseen youth development across the under-11, under-13, under-15, under-17 and reserve sides.

Stellenbosch completes redemption arc

Stellenbosch Football Club, the runner-up in the last edition of the tournament, ensured that another

English team did not best them this time around.

Having lost to Wolverhampton Wanderers 4-5 on penalties last year, the Stellies left nothing to chance, putting the game to bed in regulation time at the Loughborough University Stadium in Leicestershire.

Captain Shaakir Ahmed netted the opening goal before the 20-minute mark, leaving Spurs goalkeeper Samuel Archer unmoved, and set up Kyle Bailey in the box just before halftime, prompting a huge cheer from a group of the club's fans in the United Kingdom.

There was also a lesson here for Indian clubs: consistency in youth development is key to long-term success.

This was Stellenbosch's third consecutive appearance in the tournament, and each time, it reached the final, winning the Midlands final in 2022 and the single knockout one this time.

Indian football might have seen a few silver linings in the successes of Stellenbosch and Punjab FC, but it is time to build on these achievements before it's too late.